

CHARACTERISTICS OF AN OVERCOMER

TEXT: **Romans 8:35-39** *“Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword? ³⁶As it is written, For thy sake we are killed all the day long; we are accounted as sheep for the slaughter. ³⁷Nay, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him that loved us. ³⁸For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, ³⁹Nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.”*

INTRO: In our Scripture text Paul is writing to the Roman Christians, and he says very boldly that many things will attempt to separate the child of God from the love of God!

Let me be brutally honest in telling you that I do not believe you can do anything that will keep God from loving you! However there are some things you can do that will take you out of his presence! When his presence is lost there will be defeat instead of victory in your life! You will no longer be an **“OVERCOMER”**, you will be repeatedly defeated! The reason for this? Paul very plainly says, the enemy...

- ... Will try to trip us up by sending tribulation!
- ... Will try to throw us off track by distressing us!
- ... Will try to get us to cave in to persecution!
- ... Will attempt to make us believe God doesn't care, by attacking our food supply!
 - ... Will try to discourage us through lack of adequate clothing!
 - ... Will try to make us feel unprotected and threatened, by setting up circumstances that feel dangerous to us!
- ... Try to make us feel inferior by physically threatening us!
- ... Plans to kill us, every day... all day long!
- ... Considers us as sheep, headed for the slaughter!
- ... Plans to kill us with death!
- ... Plans to destroy us with life!
- ... Tries to deceive us by transforming himself into an angel!

The list of ways the enemy tries to keep us from being an **“OVERCOMER”** goes on!

Paul knew all of this yet he says **Romans 8:37** *“Nay, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him that loved us.”*

Paul is saying that we are **“OVERCOMERS”** in spite of what the enemy might, or might not do! The definition of an **“OVERCOMER”** is, **“a person who overcomes, vanquishes, or surmounts”**! My personal definition of an **“OVERCOMER”** is **“a person who finds a way to rise a little higher than the circumstance they are surrounded by”**!

Not all Christians are **“OVERCOMERS”**! (Sorry, I didn't mean to shock you!)

I am convinced there are at least three ways to identify an **“OVERCOMER”**! You can identify an **“OVERCOMER”** by their love, their life, and their liberty!

I. YOU CAN SPOT AN OVERCOMER BY THE LOVE THEY PUT ON DISPLAY!

A. Many people who call themselves Christian say they **“LOVE”** God, and they should (What’s not to love about God?), but they never learn to like the rest of God’s family very much! These kind of people are always defeated!

Jesus said in **John 13:35** ***“By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another.”***

In order to be an **“OVERCOMER”** you must learn to **“LOVE”** God’s family, which has become your adopted family, now that you have become a son or daughter of God! When you agreed to marry Jesus, you agreed to marry his whole family! (You’re friends you can pick, your family you’re stuck with!)

B. Now that you know you are going to have to learn to **“LOVE”** your adopted family, how much **“LOVE”** must you have? **John 15:12** ***“This is my commandment, That ye love one another, as I have loved you.”***

Romans 12:9 ***“Love must be sincere. Hate what is evil; cling to what is good.”***

1 Peter 1:22 ***“Seeing ye have purified your souls in obeying the truth through the Spirit unto unfeigned (Sincere) love of the brethren, see that ye love one another with a pure heart fervently:”***

That word **“fervently”** means intently, or red hot! (As the young people would say, we need to have the HOT’S for the family of God!)

An **“OVERCOMER”** will be guilty of **PDA!** (Public displays of affection!)

C. You can write this down, a person who is constantly bad mouthing their brothers and sisters is not an **“OVERCOMING”** Christian!

I promise you they have gross failures in their own lives, therefore they are attempting to bring someone else down to make themselves look better!

A parent who **“LOVES”** their child does not want to subject them to public humiliation when they have failed! In fact they will attack anyone who does!

You can spot an **“OVERCOMER”** by the **“LOVE”** they place on public display for their God, and the rest of his children!

If you **“LOVE”** God prove it by **“LOVING”** me and the rest of your adopted family!

II. YOU CAN SPOT AN OVERCOMER BY THE LIFE THEY LIVE!

A. The “LIFE” of an “OVERCOMER” will be marked by their desire to pray and study the Word of God! **Psalm 119:11**

“I have hidden your word in my heart that I might not sin against you.”

Sometimes what the Bible does not say is as important as what it does say! Such is the case here, this Scripture say’s ***“If you hide God’s Word inside you, you will not be as likely to sin against Him”!***

What it does not say, but most certainly implies is ***“If you fail to hide His Word in your heart you will most certainly sin against Him”!***

Thus I believe we could safely say that “YOU CAN SPOT AN OVERCOMER” by their desire to get into the Word of God!

John 15:7 ***“If ye abide in me, and my words abide in you, ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you.”***

A person who studies the Word of God as they should looks like an “OVERCOMER”! Acts like an “OVERCOMER”! Reacts like an “OVERCOMER”! Walks like an “OVERCOMER”! Talks like an “OVERCOMER”! What is the reason for this? Because they have equipped themselves to “OVERCOME”! **2 Tim. 2:15** ***“Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.”***

B. The “LIFE” of an “OVERCOMER” will be marked by their desire to be around the people of God! **Hebrews 10:23-25**

“Let us hold fast the profession of our faith without wavering; (for he is faithful that promised;) ²⁴And let us consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works: ²⁵Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as the manner of some is; but exhorting one another: and so much the more, as ye see the day approaching.”

A lot of people don’t think church attendance is all that important, but I want you to consider this;

While living as a mere mortal on this Earth, Jesus himself became a habitual church-goer!

Luke 4:16 ***“And he came to Nazareth, where he had been brought up: and, as his custom was, he went into the synagogue on the sabbath day, and stood up for to read.”***

Paul, and the other Apostles attended church! **Acts 13:14**

“But when they departed from Perga, they came to Antioch, and went into the synagogue on the sabbath day, and sat down.”

If Jesus and Paul needed to go to church (As dead as the church was in their day), what makes you think you can be an “OVERCOMER” without going? Who do you think you are?

C. The “LIFE” of an “OVERCOMER” will be marked by an attitude of victory despite difficult circumstances! **2 Cor. 11:24-28** *“Five times I received from the Jews the forty lashes minus one. ²⁵Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was shipwrecked, I spent a night and a day in the open sea, ²⁶I have been constantly on the move. I have been in danger from rivers, in danger from bandits, in danger from my own countrymen, in danger from Gentiles; in danger in the city, in danger in the country, in danger at sea; and in danger from false brothers. ²⁷I have labored and toiled and have often gone without sleep; I have known hunger and thirst and have often gone without food; I have been cold and naked. ²⁸Besides everything else, I face daily the pressure of my concern for all the churches.”*

What did Paul do about this? Give up? Quit? Whine to his spiritual authority? No!!! He was an “OVERCOMER”! Listen to this! **Acts 20:24** *“But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, and the ministry, which I have received of the Lord Jesus, to testify the gospel of the grace of God.”*

Let me ask a very simple question: If we had not previously advertised ourselves as an “OVERCOMING” Christian, and the only thing the world had to go on was the evidence we produce with our life, would they come to the conclusion that we are an “OVERCOMER”?

Do you think the world wants what we have? Our life is the only Bible most people will ever read!

III, YOU CAN SPOT AN OVERCOMER BY THE LIBERTY THEY EXERCISE!

A. An “OVERCOMER” will exercise “LIBERTY” over sinful practices! **1 John 2:1** *“My little children, these things write I unto you, that ye sin not. And if any man sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous:”*

You cannot be numbered among the “OVERCOMERS” unless you learn to possess your vessel in sanctification and honor, on a consistent basis! Living “LIBERATED” from sin is really self control 101!

There are those who would have us to believe:

We have no control over sinful practices and appetites! **Romans 6:12-13** *“Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body, that ye should obey it in the lusts thereof. ¹³Neither yield ye your members as instruments of unrighteousness unto sin: but yield yourselves unto God, as those that are alive from the dead, and your members as instruments of righteousness unto God.”*

We must sin every day! **1 Cor. 15:34** *“Awake to righteousness, and sin not; for some have not the knowledge of God: I speak *this* to your shame.”*

God understands! We're only human!!! - Humans are the only species who have the potential of being numbered among the **"OVERCOMERS"**, and if you want to be an **"OVERCOMER"** you must first **"OVERCOME"** sin!

B. An **"OVERCOMER"** will exercise **"LIBERTY"** in their ministry! Everyone under the sound of my voice should have a ministry! If you have not yet been called to a ministry one of several things is going on in your life:

You are ignorant of the Word of God, both written and verbal! (Some people have spent an entire lifetime waiting for God to **"CALL"** them to do something!)

You have not been listening to what the Lord is saying in your life! (Too many competing distractions!)

You are walking in direct rebellion to the known will of God! (Sometimes we slip into rebellion almost without realizing it, and then we feed the rebellion by searing our conscious by justifying our actions!)

At any rate we need to discover our ministry!

Become comfortable with where the Lord has chosen to plant us!

Strive to become all we can be for God! Paul talking to Timothy said, [2 Tim. 2:15](#) **"Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth."** The NIV says [2 Tim. 2:15](#) **"Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a workman who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly handles the word of truth."**

Notice what Paul has to say about the ministry to which the Lord had called him! [Acts 20:24](#) **"But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, and the ministry, which I have received of the Lord Jesus, to testify the gospel of the grace of God."**

Your Ministry was not designed to be a hardship, but a **JOY!** (Preacher that I talked to recently! He hates being a Preacher or Pastor! I dare say he missed his calling!)

People rarely succeed unless they enJOY what they are doing! God wants you to experience **"LIBERTY"** with regard to your ministry! God doesn't want your ministry to be a burden, he wants it to be a blessing! (If your child was terribly unhappy with their work situation, would you want them to find a job they would enJOY more? God is your Heavenly Father!)

"OVERCOMERS" are always involved in a ministry they enJOY!

C. An **"OVERCOMER"** will exercise **"LIBERTY"** in their worship!

The Psalmist David was a man who had feet of clay, and made his fair share of mistakes, but he was also a man who was in the truest sense of the word “**LIBERATED**” in his worship!

Psalm 103:1-5 *“Bless the Lord, O my soul: and all that is within me, bless his holy name. ²Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits: ³Who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases; ⁴Who redeemeth thy life from destruction; who crowneth thee with lovingkindness and tender mercies; ⁵Who satisfieth thy mouth with good things; so that thy youth is renewed like the eagle's.”*

I believe one of the main ingredients in the life of David that developed him into an “**OVERCOMER**”, was his “**LIBERTY**” to worship in good times and bad times alike!

Under the Old Testament economy, the Ark represented the physical, tangible presence of Jehovah God! When King David was bringing the Ark back home to Jerusalem, he experienced “**LIBERTY**” in his worship! **2 Samuel 6:14-15** *“And David danced before the Lord with all his might; and David was girded with a linen ephod. ¹⁵So David and all the house of Israel brought up the ark of the Lord with shouting, and with the sound of the trumpet.”*

If we ever hope to be an “**OVERCOMER**” we will need to learn to worship, despite the circumstances!